whatever steps we take, you know, laws which are conducive to our beliefs, it should be. So they also should not have a problem with the way we live, and we also should not have a problem with the way they live.'[67]

This is the tightrope the BJP must walk on the issue of beef and cow slaughter in the Northeast. As Sethi and Shubrastha write, 'Issues like the beef ban will continuously implore the BJP leadership to dovetail two very contrasting viewpoints—respecting the customary food habits of the North-east on the one hand and balancing the pressures emanating from the Hindi heartland to ban cow slaughter. How effectively the party leaders can take these challenging issues head-on will determine the future prospects of the party in the region.'[68]

The BJP's Five Strategies Within the Northeast

The party adopted five broad strategies within the Northeast to drive its expansion in these new catchment areas. The cornerstone of its approach was mergers and acquisitions, that is, to bring into its tent a range of defectors from rival parties as well as local notables with diverse followings. It also focused on building coalitions and new anti-Congress alliances to broaden its political support base. This meant strategic realignments to co-opt core electoral groups and adroit management of the electoral arithmetic of communities in each state to build winning alliances. The BJP also leveraged its position as the party in office in Delhi. This is especially crucial for states in the Northeast and gave an additional incentive to parties in the region to align with it. It combined these strategies with a sharp focus on the delivery of development projects. Significantly, its grassroots membership drive in the region unfolded in tandem with longer-term ideological penetration by the wider RSS network. Finally, its success in Assam was built on a model of ethno-religious mobilisation predicated on a narrative of Hindus in peril and the social fissures opened up by 'illegal immigration'.

Strategy 1: Mergers and Acquisitions